MUDRA MAESTRA



SHALINI JAIN

Malavika Sarukkai, *64*
Bharatanatyam exponent

YOU ONLY LIVE ONCE

"Please know that you are a person in your own right; live it to your full potential"

↘ **SWEET SURRENDER** **Chocolate cake**

↘ **BEFORE GETTING ON STAGE... she likes to stand in the wings in complete silence**

↘ **SOURCE OF ENERGY Was a 'Complan girl' once**

As a student of dance, love songs were very special to me," says Bharatanatyam exponent Malavika Sarukkai. "I liked the flavour of love poetry; the tumble of emotions that are such an intrinsic part of life."

But sometime in her late 20s, after a few years of engaging with the *sringara rasa*, Malavika found herself questioning it. "I began looking at the position of the woman created by poets, and felt I was conditioned to portray women in a particular way...I felt compelled to free myself and see my body as a dancing body with a movement vocabulary that could uninhibitedly express whatever that I wanted to," she says. It was intimidating at first, like stepping out of a safe space, admits Malavika.

For over five decades now, Malavika has inhabited dance on her own terms. "If I want to say something very much, I dance it; if I feel strongly about something, I create a work in dance." Take 'Anubandh–Connectedness' (2022), her solo, path-breaking work that explores the relationship between nature and life, and becomes an ode of sorts to the power and potential of hope.

With an intent to nurture dancers in a manner that they are awakened by the possibilities of rigour and technique and of fine-tuning the dancing body, Malavika's Kalavaahini Trust has been curating the Dance Immersion Programme (DIP) since 2016. "I hope to inspire dancers to not take dance for granted and to find a sense of fullness in it...," she says.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Hugely influential, she is committed to nurturing the future possibilities in dance

Growing up in a feminine household, with her grandmother, Meenakshi, mother, Saroja Kamakshi and sister Priya for company, Malavikacontinues to resist the patriarchy that persists in Indian classical dance. "I've felt that I live the moment more intensely," she says, "and dance has that quality to centre you. Now I tell people, I welcome you to come with me on a journey, but for that you have to be vulnerable and be okay going home." ■

–Akhila Krishnamurthy